

A Different History



SUMMARY

The ancient goat god Pan isn't dead, the speaker declares; he just moved to India. In India, the gods wander around in the shape of snakes or monkeys. Trees are holy, and it's sinful to be rude to books. It's sinful to kick a book, to put it down too hard, to chuck it across the room. In India, the speaker says, people have to learn to read books gently, without startling Sarasvati (the goddess of arts and learning) or being rude to the trees used to make the book's paper.

The speaker now wonders: is there any language that hasn't been the language of oppression? Has any language ever really meant to kill anybody? And how is it that when the cruelty is over—after the oppressors have cut out the souls of the people they oppress with the long blade that shoots from their faces—how is it that, afterwards, the as-yet-unborn descendants of the oppressed come to love the language their ancestors' oppressors spoke?

"unborn grandchildren" of oppressed people in colonized countries may actually "grow to love" the "strange language" that their ancestors' oppressors foisted on them. For that matter, they may use that language to criticize the oppressive culture that *brought* them that language.

This poem—written in English by a poet born in India—embodies exactly the situation it describes. Bhatt uses the English language to reflect on the violence that the British inflicted on her native country—including the violence of imposing the English language on a region rich in regional languages and dialects. The poem thus makes the point that language has a life of its own; it won't be bound to any one set of people or goals.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-29



THEMES



LANGUAGE AS A LIVING, POWERFUL FORCE

In India, this poem's speaker observes, "it is a sin / to be rude to a book"—for books have their own kind of life, a special power and identity of their own that should be honored. The same, Sujata Bhatt suggests, is true of language itself: language is a powerful tool, but also a living creature. While people can try to control language or use it for their own (often cruel) purposes, language escapes those bounds, sometimes turning against the very people who used it as a weapon.

The poem reflects on the role that language can play in oppression—particularly in colonial oppression, as in the case of the Raj in India (the period of British colonial rule). An "oppressor's tongue" can do great harm to the oppressed, the speaker observes. For instance, an oppressor's language can drive out native languages, attacking a culture at its roots. An oppressor's language can also be used to order and justify violence, swooping in like a "long scythe" to inflict literal or [metaphorical](#) "torture."

However, the speaker goes on, no language *in itself* ever "truly meant to murder someone." The "oppressor's tongue" itself isn't the oppressive force here, in other words: the trouble is all in how a language gets used.

And language certainly isn't bound to the people who first used it, or to their goals. Eventually, the speaker observes, even the



POSTCOLONIAL IDENTITY AND AMBIVALENCE

"A Different History" explores what it means to have roots in a postcolonial India. The British colonized India for nearly a century. Through British rule, India was forever changed, permanently inflected by the foreign culture and language that the British violently imposed. The complex aftereffects of this colonialism, the poem suggests, can be both traumatic and enriching for those who experience them—and a postcolonial identity can thus feel ambivalent.

Colonialism, the speaker reflects, leaves trauma in its wake. In particular, the speaker examines the way that the "oppressor's tongue"—the oppressor's language, that is—can be a weapon, a "long scythe" wielded to destroy the "soul[s]" of the oppressed people. There's no forgetting such "torture."

But after the acute phase of violence and oppression has passed and the colonizers have withdrawn, colonialism leaves a complex legacy, for better and for worse. The "unborn grandchildren" of the people oppressed by colonialism—later generations of postcolonial people in general, that is—can "grow to love" elements of what the oppressive culture left behind. This poem reflects specifically on the way that a "strange language" can become a familiar, beloved friend to postcolonial people, even though that same language was used as a weapon against their ancestors. (This very poem enacts that process: Bhatt, born in India, writes much of her poetry in English.)

To belong to a postcolonial culture, then, is to experience a kind of double vision. People with a postcolonial identity can come to feel that parts of their colonizers' culture are now their own,

familiar and friendly. But they might also feel a certain ambivalence even about those parts of that culture they have come to love, knowing that they inherit these good things only through a legacy of violent domination.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-18
- Lines 19-29



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-6

*Great Pan is ...
... tree is sacred*

"A Different History" begins with a striking image of gods on the move. "Great Pan," the speaker declares, is "not dead" after all: he just "emigrated / to India."

These lines [allude](#) to an [old, old story](#) in which a sailor is instructed by a mysterious voice to proclaim that "the great god Pan is dead." Pan was a classical god: half-man, half-goat, he was the patron of woodlands and wildernesses. He was also the only one of the Greco-Roman gods ever said to have died.

The story of Pan's death became meaningful to later Christian writers:

- Some theorized that Pan's death represented the end of the pagan world and the coming of the Christian era.
- Some, meanwhile, suggested that the dead Pan *prefigured* Christ. Since the prefix "pan-" means "all" in Greek, Pan's death could be read as [foreshadowing](#) the death of the Christian God—a monotheistic god of "all"—at the Crucifixion. Again, the story suggests the rise of the Christian world and the fading of the pagan one.

In this poem, however, Pan never died. He just got up and moved to India. In India, the poem suggests, Pan can feel more at home, fitting in among gods who "roam freely / disguised as snakes or monkeys." The Hindu tradition of India, in other words, is far more accommodating and welcoming to an old god like Pan than the Christianized West could be. Alongside [Hanuman](#) the monkey god and the elephant-headed [Ganesha](#), Pan can go on doing what he does in the woods, unhindered by monotheism.

By presenting Pan as an immigrant to India, Bhatt slyly introduces a postcolonial note to this poem. For the immigrant Pan is moving in the opposite direction to a lot of Indian immigrants. Since the Raj (the long period of British colonialism in India) ended in 1947, many more people have emigrated from

India than have immigrated to India: there are robust Indian expat communities in the U.K., the U.S., and many other Western countries. Sujata Bhatt's own parents emigrated from India to the U.S. when Bhatt was a child.

Pan, like the people of the Indian diaspora, moves in search of opportunity. But his plan is to escape the Christian West—and he's doing so, oddly, by moving to a country deeply marked by British colonial oppression.

These few quick opening lines thus introduce a complex world of clashing cultures. While India has been colonized by the same Western Christians that drove the old pagan gods out of the Mediterranean, Bhatt suggests, it also preserves its very different religious and cultural traditions, in spite of it all. In going to India, Pan can still escape to a place where the gods disguise themselves as animals, where "every tree is sacred." This will be a poem about the way that an oppressed culture survives and evolves around colonialism—and especially the role that *language* plays in such adaptation.

Bhatt will explore these ideas in [free verse](#), with no regular [meter](#) or [rhyme scheme](#). The poem's changeable shape will sometimes feel reflective, sometimes passionate. Consider the rhythm of the first three lines, for example:

Great Pan is not dead;
he simply emigrated
to India.

By unfolding this sentence over three short lines, Bhatt emphasizes striking words and ideas. The [enjambment](#) in "he simply **emigrated / to India**," for instance, lends some extra weight to the word "emigrated," lodging it prominently at the end of a line.

LINES 7-14

*and it is ...
... across a room.*

Pan, the speaker goes on, might feel more at home in India than in the West because the Hindu pantheon (that is, Hinduism's roster of gods) is broader and more accommodating than monotheistic Western Christianity. But Pan might also prefer India because of the way that India approaches the world of nature, the world of objects, and the world of language. In India, the speaker observes, "it is a sin / to be rude to a book."

It's *such* a sin, in fact, that the speaker elaborates at length on all the ways one absolutely must not treat a book, framing the lines with emphatic [parallelism](#):

[...] it is a sin
to be rude to a book.
It is a sin to shove a book aside
with your foot,

a sin to slam books down
hard on a table,
a sin to toss one carelessly
across a room.

Focusing in on a distinctly Indian reverence for books here, the speaker introduces the idea of an animate world in which a book is a living creature that one can respect or disrespect. By implication, *language* might also be a living creature that can be treated in lots of different ways, more or less reverent.

These lines imagine the ways that a person might mistreat a book not just "carelessly," but aggressively. The speaker is less worried about dog-eared pages and coffee stains than they are about people "shov[ing]," "slam[ming]," and "toss[ing]" books—practically beating them up. These images of violence against books and words will come into thematic focus in the second stanza of the poem, where the speaker will suggest that violence against language can become a tool of colonial oppression in particular.

LINES 15-18

*You must learn ...
... paper was made.*

In India, this speaker says, right-thinking people recognize violence against books as a "sin," an insult to something sacred. That's partly because books are protected by a goddess of their own: Sarasvati, the Hindu goddess of learning and the arts. To read a book rightly, the speaker suggests, one must "turn the pages gently" or risk "disturbing" this goddess.

Abusing a book might also injure the feelings of the "tree / from whose wood the paper was made." This line suggests that a distinctive feature of Hinduism is its respect for nature as well as for the divine—or its sense that nature and the divine aren't really different things. The tree, here, seems like a living and sacred being, deserving respect as much as Sarasvati herself does.

This idea connects back to the thought that Pan—a god of the woods, remember—might feel more at home in India than in a Western world that has lost its reverence for nature. It also suggests that there's an intimate relationship between the written word, the gods, and the natural world. A book, here, is a collaborative production between the goddess of writing, the spirits of the trees, and humanity.

Bhatt underscores this idea of a respectful interconnection between people, nature, and the gods with [anaphora](#):

You must learn how to turn the pages gently
without disturbing Sarasvati,
without offending the tree
from whose wood the paper was made.

The repeated "without" suggests that Sarasvati and the tree are to be honored equally. Meanwhile, some subtle [assonance](#)—the /ee/ of "gently," "Sarasvati," and "tree," the /ay/ of "paper" and "made"—makes the passage sound fittingly harmonious.

LINES 19-22

*Which language ...
... to murder someone?*

As the second stanza begins, the speaker abruptly introduces a pair of sharp [rhetorical questions](#), using yet more emphatic [anaphora](#):

Which language
has not been the oppressor's tongue?
Which language
truly meant to murder someone?

The [parallelism](#) here puts these quite different ideas into dialogue.

On the one hand, the speaker asks, has any language not been the language of oppression? In other words: what language hasn't been used as a weapon?

In the context of the first stanza, this question feels particularly relevant to the Indian experience of British colonialism. Colonizing forces often insist that the places they colonize adopt their language, or at the very least give it a position of power—for instance, as the official or governmental language. A big part of Britain's colonialism in India was just such an imposition of English on a region [rich in languages and dialects](#).

But this, the speaker reflects, isn't the *language's* fault. The language itself can't have "truly meant to murder someone": language isn't inherently a weapon. It just gets used that way. This intense line [personifies](#) language, making it into an innocent and bewildered dupe in an oppressor's game: it never intended to kill.

By introducing these two questions one after the other, the speaker raises the poem's stakes considerably. The first stanza provided a gentle examination of a characteristically Indian reverence for books and nature. The speaker's critique of a more materialistic, less open-minded Western perspective was only implied in those lines. Now, ideas about language as a tool of oppression and violence surge to the front.

LINES 23-29

*And how does ...
... that strange language.*

As the poem closes, the speaker's reflections on language as a tool of oppression become darker, but also more ambivalent. First, the speaker introduces a disturbing [metaphor](#) of language as a "long scythe" that comes "swooping out of the

conqueror's face," "tortur[ing]" the very "soul[s]" of an oppressed people. Here, an "oppressor's tongue" mows down souls like the Grim Reaper. Language gets used to destroy.

Readers might reflect on the many ways this could happen. A language could be a weapon in the sense that it wipes out or stomps down a different language. It could also be a weapon in the sense that it's used to justify cruelty or exert power. Giving an oppressed people an insulting name, describing them as second-class citizens, or ordering their torture might all be ways in which an "oppressor's tongue" could be used for violence.

And yet, the speaker observes: even "after the torture," after a horrible and memorable period of oppression in which language has played a key role, the "unborn grandchildren" of an oppressed people might "grow to love that strange language."

In this closing line, the whole poem comes into focus. Sujata Bhatt, a poet born in India, is here using English—a language she spoke as a child and the language she came to use most when her family moved to the U.S.—to reflect on the way that English (and *the* English) have done violence to her native country. Clearly, this poet has come to "love that strange language," to use it as a tool of her own. She's also using it to criticize the colonizers who thrust it on her ancestors.

Language, then, has a great and ambivalent power. Though it can be used as a dreadful weapon, its strength can also be reclaimed and repurposed. While the "grandchildren" of the oppressed might feel some unease about loving the language of their oppressors, they might also be able to make that language their own.

This self-reflexive poem thus becomes an examination of the whole tradition of Anglo-Indian poetry (poetry by Indian authors written in English)—or, as Bhatt prefers to call it, "Indian-English" poetry. That very preference for a term that puts "Indian" first exemplifies the poem's point: language has the power to shape how we think and see.



POETIC DEVICES

REPETITION

[Parallelism](#) gives the speaker's language its measured, thoughtful pace. As they reflect on the honored place that books take in Indian society, for instance, the speaker uses this evolving stream of parallel language:

and it is a sin
to be rude to a book.
It is a sin to shove a book aside
[...]
a sin to slam books down

[...]
a sin to toss one carelessly

These lines emphasize how many ways one can "sin" against a book in Indian culture. The repeated language makes the speaker sound solemn, even stern, as they warn that books have their own kind of sacred life that must be respected.

They explain why this is so in lines that use some similarly emphatic [anaphora](#):

You must learn how to turn the pages gently
without disturbing Sarasvati,
without offending the tree
from whose wood the paper was made.

Here, the parallelism helps to connect Sarasvati (the Hindu goddess of learning and the arts) and the trees. The gods and nature have a life and a power of their own, these echoing words suggest. Books are sacred both because a goddess protects them and because the natural world has its own consciousness and its own holiness (and there's no making a book without asking something of the natural world). This moment of anaphora stresses the idea that Indian culture perceives the whole world as animate and sacred.

At the beginning of the second stanza, meanwhile, the speaker introduces a pair of important questions with powerful [anaphora](#):

Which language
has not been the oppressor's tongue?
Which language
truly meant to murder someone?

The mirrored language here plays these questions against each other. Many languages—maybe all languages—have in some sense been violent, the speaker suggests: oppressive cultures have used their languages as tools of oppression, supplanting the languages of the places they've attacked or colonized. But the languages *themselves* weren't the murderous oppressors. By introducing these contrasting ideas with the same words, the speaker gets at their ambivalence over the fact that the descendants of the oppressed can also eventually form a "lov[ing]" relationship with an "oppressor's tongue."

They make it clear that this change is no uncomplicated thing with yet another moment of emphatic parallelism. A language's transformation from foe to friend, they say, comes:

[...] **after** the torture,
after the soul has been cropped
with a long scythe swooping out
of the conqueror's face—

An oppressor's language, this passage suggests, inflict great violence on the "soul" of the oppressed. The pointed, doubled "after" insists that this violence not be forgotten just because it's in the past.

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 11:** "a sin to slam books down"
- **Line 13:** "a sin to toss one carelessly"
- **Line 16:** "without"
- **Line 17:** "without"
- **Line 19:** "Which language"
- **Line 21:** "Which language"
- **Line 24:** "after"
- **Line 25:** "after"

ALLUSION

"A Different History" [alludes](#) to two religious traditions: those of ancient Greece and Rome (now remembered only as mythology) and the living tradition of Hinduism. These traditions, the poem suggests, bear certain similarities: both take a reverent view of the natural world, and both have been assailed by Western Christianity.

The poem begins with an allusion to Pan, the classical god of the woods and fields, usually depicted as a satyr (a half-man, half-goat figure). According to tradition, Pan was the only one of the immortal gods to have died. An old story goes that a sailor was told to spread the word that "the great god Pan is dead." Later Christian philosophers and theologians would run with this story:

- Some suggested that Pan's death signaled the decline of the pagan world after the birth of Christ—the demise of the "[false and lying gods](#)," as [Dante](#) described them.
- Alternately, some suggested that this story prefigured the Crucifixion. Since the word "pan" means "all" in Greek, the idea was that the report of Pan's death [foreshadowed](#) Christ's death on the cross.

This poem's speaker contradicts both of those narratives. Here, Pan (and the nature-worshiping ways he represents) didn't die when Christianity came along, and he wasn't just a representative for Christ. Rather, he high-tailed it to India, where the religious landscape of Hinduism was more welcoming to him.

In India, the speaker observes, "the gods roam freely, / disguised as snakes or monkeys." And indeed, the gods of Hinduism take on all sorts of animal forms: the god Hanuman is represented as a monkey, the god Ganesha has an elephant's head. The goatish Pan clearly fits in here better than he does in a Christianized Western world.

The allusion to Pan invites readers to consider the ways in which the religions of India and the religions of the ancient Mediterranean have alike been persecuted by the West. Christianity long ago won out over ancient pagan religion in Europe. Under the colonial rule of the British, Christianity also once threatened Hinduism in India: Christian colonizers attempted unsuccessfully to stamp out what they similarly considered a pagan religion.

The poem alludes more directly to one Hindu deity in particular: the goddess Sarasvati, the patron of learning and the arts. Sarasvati, in this poem, is a protective presence, watching over *books* in particular. Under Sarasvati's eye, a book must be treated with respect, as if it were a living thing.

Where Allusion appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-3:** "Great Pan is not dead; / he simply emigrated / to India."
- **Lines 4-5:** "Here, the gods roam freely, / disguised as snakes or monkeys;"
- **Lines 15-16:** "You must learn how to turn the pages gently / without disturbing Sarasvati,"

METAPHOR

The poem presents language as a living creature and a weapon—[metaphors](#) that capture language's strange, ambivalent power.

In lines 21-22, the speaker [personifies](#) language: "Which language," they ask, "truly meant to murder someone?" This question feels especially loaded in the wake of lines 19-20, in which the speaker sadly wonders if any language has "not been the oppressor's tongue," the tool of violent people. These lines get at the odd relationship language bears to its speakers. Language is very human, and it has great power, whether for good or ill. But a language *itself* can't kill anybody and can't want to. It's all in how it's used. Yet the personification here presents language as something different from its speakers, as a creature with its own desires.

Alas, in cruel mouths, language becomes a weapon. The speaker imagines an "oppressor's tongue" (an oppressor's language, that is) as a "long scythe swooping out / of the conqueror's face," mowing down the "soul[s]" of the oppressed. This image reflects on the way that language can be destructive. By attempting to kill and replace the language of an oppressed people, an "oppressor's tongue" can also destroy souls: a language, the poem suggests, captures something of a culture's very essence.

Where Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Lines 21-22:** "Which language / truly meant to murder someone?"

- **Lines 25-27:** “after the soul has been cropped / with a long scythe swooping out / of the conqueror's face—”

ENJAMBMENT

The poem's [enjambments](#) help to frame and highlight striking ideas. For instance, take a look at the way enjambments unfold in lines 2-3:

Great Pan is not dead;
he simply **emigrated**
to India.

By breaking this line here, the speaker adds a little extra emphasis to two tongue-in-cheek—but pointed—ideas. First, the line break after “emigrated” gives that surprising word plenty of its own space, inviting readers to stay with the image of a god as an immigrant, harried out of his native land. The conclusion of the sentence—“to India”—also gets space of its own, emphasizing that Pan is traveling in the opposite direction to many post-colonial Indian emigrants (like Bhatt herself, whose family emigrated from India to the U.S. when she was young).

Enjambments also shape the poem's rhythm and atmosphere, as in lines 9-14:

It is a sin to shove a book **aside**
with your foot,
a sin to slam books **down**
hard on a table,
a sin to toss one **carelessly**
across a room.

These enjambments fall in spots where one wouldn't typically pause in everyday speech, lending a fittingly jolting, violent energy to this description of the ways in which one mustn't mistreat books.

Similarly, lines 19-22 use enjambments to [juxtapose](#) two different sides of the speaker's thoughts about speaking and writing in an “oppressor's tongue”:

Which **language**
has not been the oppressor's tongue?
Which **language**
truly meant to murder someone?

These line breaks leave the [repeated](#) words “Which language” on lines of their own, highlighting the fact that the speaker is asking two contrasting questions about language: haven't they all been used as tools of oppression by violent people? And aren't they all *in themselves* innocent of that violence?

Where Enjambment appears in the poem:

- **Lines 2-3:** “emigrated / to”
- **Lines 7-8:** “sin / to”
- **Lines 9-10:** “aside / with”
- **Lines 11-12:** “down / hard”
- **Lines 13-14:** “carelessly / across”
- **Lines 17-18:** “tree / from”
- **Lines 19-20:** “language / has”
- **Lines 21-22:** “language / truly”
- **Lines 23-24:** “happen / that”
- **Lines 25-26:** “cropped / with”
- **Lines 26-27:** “out / of”
- **Lines 28-29:** “grandchildren / grow”

SIBILANCE

Long stretches of [sibilant](#) language give the poem an alternately mysterious and menacing tone. In the first stanza, for instance, the speaker describe an India where:

[...] the gods roam freely,
disguised as snakes or monkeys;
every tree is sacred
and it is a sin
to be rude to a book.

The interweaving /s/ and /z/ sounds here throw a hush over this passage, suggesting a quiet reverence. In the landscape the speaker describes, just about everywhere might be imagined as a holy place where one should speak in a hush: animals, trees, and books might all embody the gods (or be protected by them). All these sounds also lead up to the introduction of the goddess Sarasvati, whose name has its own soft sibilant elegance.

There's a harsher sibilance in lines 25-27, in which the speaker imagines language as a weapon:

after the soul has been cropped
with a long scythe swooping out
of the conqueror's face—

The /s/ sounds here capture the hiss of a scythe blade “swooping” through the air, making the speaker's metaphor audible.

Where Sibilance appears in the poem:

- **Line 5:** “disguised,” “snakes,” “monkeys”
- **Line 6:** “sacred”
- **Line 7:** “sin”
- **Line 9:** “sin,” “shove”
- **Line 11:** “sin,” “slam”

- **Line 13:** "sin," "toss," "carelessly"
- **Line 14:** "across"
- **Line 16:** "disturbing Sarasvati"
- **Line 25:** "soul"
- **Line 26:** "scythe swooping"
- **Line 27:** "conqueror's face"



VOCABULARY

Great Pan (Line 1) - That is, the classical god Pan, the half-man, half-goat god of woods, wilderness, and shepherding. The line "Great Pan is not dead" [alludes](#) to a tradition that Pan was the only god to die. His death [symbolically](#) marked the passing of the ancient world and the beginning of the Christian era.

Emigrated (Lines 2-3) - Moved from one country to another.

Roam (Line 4) - Wander around.

Sarasvati (Line 16) - The Hindu goddess of the arts, knowledge, and learning. (Also sometimes spelled "Saraswati.") As [Sujata Bhatt notes](#), Sarasvati is often worshiped in libraries.

Tongue (Line 20) - Language.

Scythe (Line 26) - A farm implement used in mowing, made from a long curved blade on the end of a stick. [Symbolically](#), the scythe is also associated with death: it's the weapon traditionally carried by the Grim Reaper, who uses it to mow people down like hay.



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"A Different History" is written in [free verse](#), without a regular form, [rhyme scheme](#), or [meter](#). Bhatt divides the poem into two irregular stanzas: one of 18 lines and one of 11. The division between these stanzas marks a sharp change in pace and tone:

- The first stanza explores the idea that India is a place where wild, ancient gods live on—gods like Pan, the classical satyr-god who haunted woods. In India, the speaker suggests, the whole world is imbued with a mysterious holiness. In particular, this stanza explores the way that Indian culture treats books and trees as specially sacred.
- The second stanza, meanwhile, explores the darker power of books and language as weapons of oppression. "Conqueror[s]," the poem observes, often display their dominance over the places they conquer by installing their own languages there.

There's a self-reflexive quality in this poem. Sujata Bhatt was born in India, but her family emigrated to the U.S. when she was

12. She writes most of her poems in English—which, as this poem observes, is one of the "oppressor's tongue[s]," the language spoken by the British colonizers who exploited India for long years. Through the very act of writing this poem, Bhatt reflects on her own experience of loving a "strange language," an English that was imposed on her ancestors.

METER

This poem is written in [free verse](#), so it doesn't use a regular [meter](#). Instead, Bhatt shapes this poem's rhythms through line length, [enjambments](#), and swinging [repetitions](#). Take, for instance, the poem's first three lines:

Great Pan is not dead;
he simply emigrated
to India.

These three short lines each frame one part of a striking, funny, complex idea:

- The first line calls up a big [allusion](#): the old story that Pan was the only god ever to die, and that his death marked the rise of Christianity and the end of all of the old pagan religions in the Western world.
- The second presents Pan, not as a dead god, but as a displaced immigrant.
- The third presents him as an immigrant to India—a country better known for post-colonial [emigration](#), whose people have left to form big expat communities all over the world.

By doling these ideas out in short, sharp lines, the speaker introduces huge themes—Christian hegemony, immigration, post-colonial India—in a sparing, light, and surprising way.

RHYME SCHEME

There's no [rhyme scheme](#) in this [free verse](#) poem. Instead of using rhyme, Bhatt creates music through subtle [internal rhyme](#), [repetitions](#), and devices like [assonance](#) and [sibilance](#). Listen, for instance, to the echoes that thread through lines 15-18:

You must learn how to turn the pages gently
without disturbing Sarasvati,
without offending the tree
from whose wood the paper was made.

The internal rhyme between *learn* and *turn*, the [anaphora](#) on the word "without," and the understated assonance on /ee/ and /ay/ sounds make this passage feel delicately harmonious.



SPEAKER

There's no clearly identified speaker in this poem. However, readers who are familiar with Bhatt's biography might read the speaker as Bhatt herself. The speaker reflects on the experience of "lov[ing] a strange language"—in this case, English, a language that was imposed on Bhatt's Indian ancestors by colonial British "oppressor[s]." This poem, itself written in English, becomes a self-reflexive way for its speaker to consider their complex feelings about language and oppression.

This speaker is thoughtful about the ways in which the power of language can be used for good and ill. Language, they observe, can be an "oppressor's tongue," a tool used to cut down other ways of thinking and speaking like a "long scythe" mows down grass. However, they also note that language has a power beyond its use as a weapon. The "unborn grandchildren" of people whose native languages were suppressed or erased might eventually "grow to love that strange language," finding beauty and power of their own in the "oppressor's tongue."

These ideas and questions are clearly relevant to Bhatt herself. As an Indian poet who writes mostly in English, she uses the "oppressor's tongue" here to question the legacy of those oppressors—and her own relationship to a language she loves.



SETTING

The first part of this poem is set in India—the country to which, according to the speaker, "Great Pan" (the classical half-man, half-goat god of woods and wildernesses) has run away. In India, this speaker observes, the gods are more lively and more wild than they are in the western world that Pan came from, now that Christianity has taken over and driven the pagan gods away. The gods are also more present in people's daily lives. For instance, Sarasvati (the Hindu goddess of learning and the arts) watches over every book, so one can't just treat books as objects. In India, the speaker says, a book is a sacred, living thing.

The speaker's reflections on the holiness of books in India segues into wider thoughts about language—and history. Though the speaker never explicitly says that they're discussing India in the wake of British colonialism, their [allusions](#) to an "oppressor's tongue," [juxtaposed](#) with an image of a nature god fleeing the Christianized Western world, drop a pretty big hint that Britain's oppression of India is a major theme here. This poem isn't just set in India, then, but in an India marked by colonialism, and one whose new generations have found ways to make an "oppressor's tongue" their own.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

Sujata Bhatt (1956-present) is a contemporary Indian poet who lived in the Indian state of Gujarat for most of her childhood. She moved with her family to the United States in 1968 and received her MFA from the University of Iowa. She now lives in Germany and has published six collections of poems.

"A Different History" appeared in Bhatt's debut 1988 collection *Brunizem*. The title of the book comes from the name of a kind of soil found in India, suggesting that the roots of Bhatt's work are sunk deep in the earth of her childhood.

Bhatt's work takes part in a longstanding and rich cultural tradition of English-language poetry of Indian origin. (The work of Bengali-speaking poet [Rabindranath Tagore](#) provides probably the most famous example of this tradition.) Bhatt describes her poetry as "Indian-English," rather than using the conventional Western-centric term "Anglo-Indian."

Though Bhatt writes most of her poetry in English, she nonetheless considers the Gujarati language the "deepest layer" of her identity. This poem thus feels particularly personal, exploring the loyalty a native of a colonized country might feel toward their native language and the ambivalence they might feel about coming to love an "oppressor's tongue."

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Sujata Bhatt was born in Gujarat, one of the largest states in India—a country marked by a long colonial history. The British colonized India in the 19th century; they finally withdrew in 1947. One of the results of British rule in India is that English remains a dominant language there, particularly in education. Bhatt attended an English school as a child. Even though she was in her own country and her native language was Gujarati, she navigated two languages—the "oppressor's tongue," and her own [mother tongue](#).

Bhatt published this poem when she was living in the U.S. in the 1980s. This was the era of the Reagan administration in the U.S. and the Thatcher administration in the UK, a period of intense conservatism and anti-immigrant policies. States in the U.S. began to establish English-only laws during this decade, making it illegal for people to speak a language other than English. Bhatt here reckons with the sad fact that language has often been thus used as a tool of exclusion and oppression.



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [An Interview with Bhatt](#) — Read an interview with Bhatt in which she discusses her poetic development. (<https://www.carcanet.co.uk/cgi-bin/>)

[scribe?showdoc=4;doctype=interview\)](#)

- [Sarasvati](#) — Learn more about Sarasvati, the Hindu goddess of learning and the arts. (<https://www.worldhistory.org/Sarasvati/>)
- [The Poem Aloud](#) — Listen to a recording of Bhatt reading this poem. (<https://voetica.com/poem/11146>)
- [A Brief Biography](#) — Read a short overview of Bhatt's life. (<https://poetryarchive.org/poet/sujata-bhatt/>)
- [The Great God Pan is Dead](#) — Learn more about Pan (the god the poem's first lines allude to) and read the curious story of his supposed death. (<https://www.labrujulaverde.com/en/2023/12/pan-the-only-greek-god-whose-death-is-attested-in-historical-sources/>)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER SUJATA BHATT POEMS

- [Muliebrity](#)
- [Search For My Tongue](#)



HOW TO CITE

MLA

Nelson, Kristin. "A Different History." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 17 Jan 2025. Web. 28 Jan 2025.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Nelson, Kristin. "A Different History." LitCharts LLC, January 17, 2025. Retrieved January 28, 2025. <https://www.litcharts.com/poetry/sujata-bhatt/a-different-history>.